An LLM-driven multi-agent simulation framework for quantitative analysis of narrative voice shifts in literary texts

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ABSTRACT

Narratological accounts of first- and third-person narration rely mainly on interpretation. However, the narrative voice of a text cannot be varied while its content is held constant, so these accounts are difficult to test empirically. Therefore, we propose a multi-agent simulation framework driven by large language models that turns narrative voice into an experimental variable. A Director Agent extracts the characters of a literary excerpt and enforces the narrative mode of every turn. Actor Agents with a sliding-window memory then generate the dialogue. We simulated six excerpts by six authors with three open-weight language models and five random seeds. The modes were compared in a paired design with a no-instruction control and a rule-based transposition baseline. Third-person narration used longer and less frequent words than first-person speech, with an effect size of 0.90, and it was affectively more neutral. Lexicon-based subjectivity did not differ between the modes. Character identity was only partly preserved across modes. When the Director narrated the Actors' own speech in free indirect style, cross-mode speaker attribution rose from 0.60 to 0.73. Language-model judges and human experts, however, rated these dialogues as less coherent. These results show that multi-agent simulation with controlled narrative voice can test narratological hypotheses, and that the formal register of narration in our simulations arises from narratorial paraphrase.

Project page: https://yanlibengbu.github.io/narrative-voice-sim/
Code and data: https://github.com/YanLiBengbu/narrative-voice-sim

INTRODUCTION

The analysis of narrative perspective has been a core theme in narratology since its formalization in structuralist theory. Shifts between first-person and third-person narration shape how readers perceive who speaks, whose perceptions are rendered and how strongly a character's subjectivity is foregrounded (Onega and Landa, 1996; Bal, 2009). Classical narratologists emphasized close reading and interpretive frameworks (Baroni and Paschoud, 2021). Such interpretations are difficult to replicate and to test empirically. With the advent of computational methods, literary scholars have turned toward quantitative analysis, seeking systematic evidence for narratological phenomena (Gius and Vauth, 2022; Hatavara et al., 2024; Piper et al., 2021).

In digital literary studies, computational approaches have been applied to authorship attribution (He et al., 2024) and stylistic analysis (Herrmann et al., 2021; Khafaga and Shaalan, 2022). Other studies detected narrative point of view and diegesis (Eisenberg and Finlayson, 2016), quantified free indirect discourse (Brooke et al., 2017) and attributed quotations in novels (Vishnubhotla et al., 2022). These methods classify or describe existing texts. They cannot vary a single narratological variable while holding everything else constant. Large language models (LLMs) can extract character attributes from a passage and generate role-specific dialogue (Yu et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2025a; Shao et al., 2023). LLM agents that take on distinct roles have also been used to model social dynamics, collaborative

planning and conversational reasoning (Li et al., 2024; Sun et al., 2025; De Zarzà et al., 2023; Park et al., 2023; Wang, 2025; Rahimi et al., 2025; Zhai et al., 2025). However, computational narratology has rarely combined such multi-agent simulations with explicit control over narrative voice (Cai et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2025b).

Motivated by this, we propose an LLM-driven multi-agent simulation framework for studying narrative voice shifts under controlled conditions. A Director Agent extracts the characters and dialogue of a literary excerpt and enforces the narrative mode of every turn. The mode is first-person direct speech, third-person narration by an external narrator or a control without any perspective instruction. Actor Agents with a bounded dialogue memory generate the turns. A seeded speaker-selection policy decides who speaks next. The framework generates new dialogue conditioned on a short excerpt and does not reproduce the source novel. Our findings therefore describe how LLM agents realize narrative-voice instructions. They can support, but not establish, hypotheses about human-authored narrative. We evaluate the framework on six excerpts by six authors with three open-weight LLMs and five random seeds.

Our contributions are summarized as follows:

- We formulate narrative-voice simulation as a paired experiment in which only the narrative mode differs, and we compile six excerpts by six authors with verified casts and manually attributed quotations.
- We propose a multi-agent framework in which a Director Agent enforces the narrative mode of every turn while Actor Agents with a sliding-window memory and an addressee-aware speaker-selection policy generate role-specific dialogue.
- We develop an evaluation protocol that separates the effect of the mode instruction from that of narration with a no-instruction control and a rule-based transposition baseline, and that tests character identity with speaker attribution, LLM judges and experts.

The code, prompts, generated dialogues and analysis scripts are released on the project page and in the code repository given below the abstract.

1 RELATED WORK

1.1 Narrative voice, perspective and focalization

Narratology distinguishes two questions that the everyday term "point of view" tends to merge. *Voice* concerns who narrates. Genette (1980) calls a narrator who is a character in the story homodiegetic and a narrator who is absent from it heterodiegetic. *Focalization* concerns whose perception orients the narrative, independently of who narrates. It may be zero and unrestricted, internal and restricted to a character's perceptions, or external (Genette, 1980; Bal, 2009; Niederhoff, 2013). *Narrative perspective* is often used as an umbrella term for both dimensions (Niederhoff, 2013; Fludernik, 2009). Grammatical person is the most visible marker of voice, but it does not determine focalization. A third-person narrative can be internally focalized through a character, as in free indirect discourse (Brooke et al., 2017).

In this paper, the experimental variable is narrative voice in a narrow sense, namely the grammatical person and the narratorial mediation with which a character's turn is rendered. In the first-person mode, the turn is the character's own direct speech. In the third-person mode, a heterodiegetic narrator reports it. We do not manipulate focalization directly, although the narrator may mention the character's actions or inner states. Below, "perspective" refers to this voice manipulation.

1.2 Empirical and computational studies of narrative perspective

Reader-response experiments show that grammatical person affects how narratives are processed. Brunyé et al. (2009) found that pronouns modulate the perspective that readers adopt when they mentally simulate described events. Hartung et al. (2016) presented literary short stories with first-person or third-person pronouns. The first-person versions produced higher immersion, mainly through transportation and mental imagery, whereas appreciation was unaffected. On the computational side, Eisenberg and Finlayson (2016) identified point of view and diegesis automatically with high accuracy, chiefly from pronoun features. Brooke et al. (2017) used lexical-style models to quantify free indirect discourse, and Vishnubhotla et al. (2022) annotated a corpus for quotation and speaker attribution in novels. Piper et al. (2021) argued that computational work on narrative should be connected more closely with narrative theory. All of these

studies observe or classify existing texts. None of them varied narrative voice while holding the content of a scene constant.

1.3 Agent-Based Modeling in Narrative Contexts

The use of computational agents to simulate narrative dynamics has roots in interactive storytelling and computational narratology. Early systems such as Façade (Mateas and Stern, 2003) modeled characters as autonomous agents whose behavior responds to player interaction in real time. Cavazza et al. (2002) and Si et al. (2005) extended this paradigm by developing multi-agent systems where character goals dynamically shape story progression. Riedl and Young (2010) proposed narrative planning frameworks that balance plot coherence with character autonomy, while Swartjes and Theune (2006) introduced emergent narrative models where stories arise organically from agent interactions rather than pre-scripted sequences. Porteous and Cavazza (2009) further refined control mechanisms through planning trajectories, and Magerko et al. (2009) studied cognition in theatrical improvisation to inform agent-based models of improvised performance. However, these traditional systems relied on hand-crafted rules and symbolic planning, limiting linguistic flexibility and scalability.

1.4 LLM-based Role Play and Multi-Agent Systems

Recent advances in large language models (LLMs) have enabled the development of multi-agent frameworks, where autonomous agents interact to simulate complex social and linguistic dynamics. Park et al. (2023) showed that generative agents with memory and reflection can simulate believable everyday behavior. Shanahan et al. (2023) proposed role play as a framework for understanding what dialogue agents do. Dedicated methods train or evaluate LLMs for character role play and plot progression (Shao et al., 2023; Yu et al., 2025; Wang et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2025a). Guo et al. (2024) provide a comprehensive survey of LLM-based multi-agent systems that identifies open issues such as benchmarking. LLMs are also increasingly used as evaluators of generated text. Their ratings correlate with expert judgements in several tasks but are subject to biases such as position and self-preference effects (Zheng et al., 2023; Chiang and Lee, 2023). These systems were not designed to control the narrative voice of the generated dialogue turn by turn. Our framework positions multi-agent LLM systems not as content generators but as experimental instruments for the controlled analysis of narrative voice.

2 METHODOLOGY

2.1 System Framework

The proposed system adopts an LLM-driven multi-agent framework to simulate and analyze narrative voice shifts in literary texts. As illustrated in Fig. 1, the framework is organized into four main modules: role extraction, dialogue simulation, dialogue analysis, and comparative reporting. The system starts by taking a literary excerpt as input and initializes the environment through a *Director Agent*, which is responsible for character assignment, context extraction, and narrative mode configuration. Based on the extracted speaker–listener pairs and character traits, a set of *Actor Agents* is instantiated, each bound to a specific literary character. The excerpt is used solely to initialize agents and context; all subsequent analysis is conducted on the newly generated dialogues, not on the source text. The *Dialogue Analyzers* then compute utterance- and session-level measures of the generated dialogues. A *Vocabulary Consistency Analyzer* compares character-specific lexical distributions across modes. Finally, results are aggregated into mode-wise summaries, statistical tests and reports.

2.2 Dialogue Simulation and Narrative Modes

Scene initialization. The Director Agent first extracts the direct-speech turns of the excerpt as records of speaker, addressees and text. It then writes a short scene context and a role card for every character. A role card contains the name, gender, personality, emotional baseline in $[-1, 1]$, speech style, background and relationships of the character. Speaker labels produced by LLMs are often inconsistent; "she", "the lady" and "Miss Havisham" may all denote the same person. We therefore map the labels to a manually verified cast list with aliases and discard turns whose speaker cannot be mapped. Scene initialization runs once per excerpt and model at temperature 0. All modes and seeds share the same role cards and opening turns, so the narrative mode is the only factor that differs between paired sessions.

Narrative modes. In the *first-person* mode, each turn is the character's own direct speech without narratorial framing. In the *third-person* mode, an external narrator reports what the character says. This

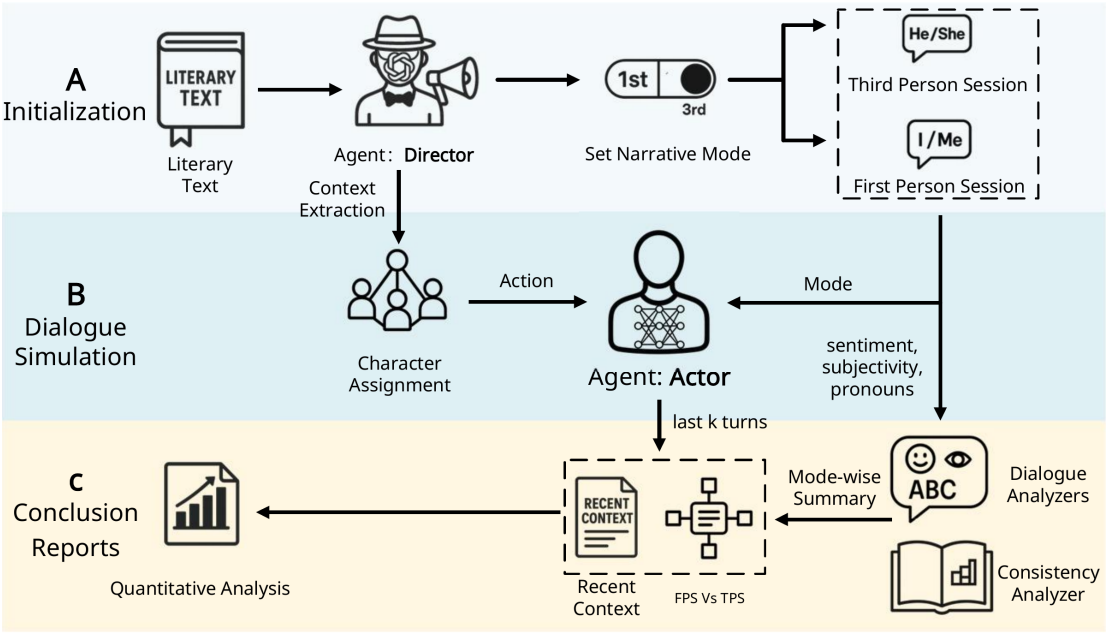


Figure 1. Overall architecture of the proposed LLM-driven multi-agent simulation framework. The system consists of role extraction, dialogue simulation under different narrative modes, multi-dimensional dialogue analysis, and comparative reporting.

narrator may mention actions or inner states, refers to the character by name or by a third-person pronoun and uses no quotation marks. In this mode, the Director also rewrites the opening turns of the excerpt into reported narration. The *neutral* control contains no perspective instruction. The Appendix gives all instructions verbatim.

Mode enforcement. After each turn, the Director applies a rule-based compliance check. A third-person turn violates the mode if it contains quotation marks or first- or second-person pronouns. It also violates the mode if it refers to the speaker neither by name nor by a third-person pronoun. A first-person turn violates the mode if it describes the speaker in the third person with a reporting verb. The Actor regenerates a non-compliant turn once with an explicit hint. If this attempt also fails, the Director rewrites the turn. For every turn, we record whether it complied at the first attempt, was regenerated, was rewritten or remained non-compliant.

Actor Agents and memory. Each Actor Agent receives its role card, the scene context, the names of the other characters and the mode instruction. It also receives the last k turns of the dialogue as a sliding-window memory, with $k = 5$ by default. The Actor returns a JSON object with its intention to speak or to remain silent, the content of the turn and its addressees.

Speaker selection. The next speaker is sampled from a softmax over addressee-aware scores computed from the truncated history H':

$$s_i = \alpha \mathbb{1}[c_i \in A_{t-1}] - \beta \mathbb{1}[c_i = c_{t-1}] + \gamma \frac{\min(g_i, |\mathscr{C}|)}{|\mathscr{C}|}, \qquad p_i = \frac{\exp(s_i/\tau)}{\sum_j \exp(s_j/\tau)}, \tag{1}$$

where s_i denotes the score of character c_i, g_i denotes the number of turns since its last turn, A_{t-1} and c_{t-1} denote the addressees and the speaker of the previous turn, $\mathscr{C}$ denotes the cast, and p_i denotes the probability that c_i speaks next. We set $\alpha = 2.0$, $\beta = 1.5$, $\gamma = 1.0$ and $\tau = 0.7$. The scores favor characters who were just addressed and penalize immediate self-succession. They also give characters who have not spoken recently a chance to take the floor. The session seed initializes the sampling.

Algorithm 1 summarizes the generation procedure. Every LLM call uses a seed derived from the session seed and the turn index. We request JSON output with constrained decoding and parse it with a deterministic repair routine, which may retry a call up to three times. Because all raw LLM responses are cached, every reported number can be regenerated from the released outputs.

Algorithm 1 Multi-agent dialogue generation with narrative-mode enforcement and reproducibility control

Input: scene (role cards, context, opening turns H_0), mode m, seed s, memory k, maximum turns $T_{\max}$
Output: dialogue $D = \{d_1, \ldots, d_T\}$
Initialize RNG(s), $H \leftarrow H_0$, $D \leftarrow \emptyset$
while $|D| < T_{\max}$ **and** fewer than 4 consecutive silent turns **do**
  $H' \leftarrow$ last k turns of H {sliding-window memory}
  compute s_i for all $c_i \in \mathscr{C}$ (Eq. 1); $c^* \sim \text{softmax}(s/\tau)$
  $r \leftarrow \text{Actor}_{c^*}(\text{card}_{c^*}, \text{context}, H', m;\ \text{seed } s_t)$ {JSON output}
  if r is a spoken turn **and** violates mode m **then**
    regenerate with a hint; if still violating, Director rewrites r into mode m
  end if
  $D \leftarrow D \cup \{r\}$; $H \leftarrow H \cup \{r\}$
end while
return D

2.3 Quantitative Analysis Methods

The analysis pipeline computes five groups of measures (see Fig. 2).

Manipulation checks. The first-person ratio is the share of first-person pronouns among all first- and third-person pronouns. This ratio and the number of self-references by name follow directly from the mode instruction. They verify the manipulation and are not treated as findings.

Outcome measures. We measure sentiment at the utterance level with three tools. A DistilBERT classifier fine-tuned on SST-2 gives the signed score $p_{\text{pos}} - p_{\text{neg}}$ (Sanh et al., 2019). TextBlob gives a polarity score (Loria, 2020), and VADER gives a second polarity score (Hutto and Gilbert, 2014). *Emotional intensity* is the absolute TextBlob polarity, and subjectivity is the TextBlob subjectivity score. Utterance length is the number of word tokens. To keep the substitution of "I" by a character name from driving the lexical measures, we compute word length and word frequency on *content words* only. Content words are alphabetic tokens other than stop words, pronouns, proper nouns and parts of character names; spaCy performs the tokenization and tagging (Honnibal et al., 2020). Word frequency is the mean Zipf frequency of the content words in the `wordfreq` lexicon (Speer, 2022). The *rare-word rate* is the share of content words with a Zipf frequency below 3. Two length-robust measures quantify lexical diversity: the moving-average type–token ratio (MATTR) with a window of 50 tokens (Covington and McFall, 2010) and the measure of textual lexical diversity (MTLD) (McCarthy and Jarvis, 2010).

Interaction measures. Turn-taking balance is the normalized entropy of the distribution of turns over characters, where 1 denotes perfectly balanced turns. Addressee responsiveness is the share of turns whose speaker was addressed in the previous turn. Self-succession is the share of consecutive turns by the same speaker. Repetition is one minus the proportion of distinct word trigrams in a session.

Character consistency. For a character c and a mode m, we pool the content words and the utterance-level sentiment classes over all seeds. From these pools, we compute the distributions of word length P_{len}, Zipf-frequency band P_{freq} and sentiment class P_{sent}, which is positive, neutral or negative. The Jensen–Shannon divergence (Lin, 1991) between two distributions P and Q is

$$\text{JS}(P \,\|\, Q) = \tfrac{1}{2}\text{KL}(P \,\|\, M) + \tfrac{1}{2}\text{KL}(Q \,\|\, M), \qquad M = \tfrac{1}{2}(P+Q), \tag{2}$$

where KL denotes the Kullback–Leibler divergence and M denotes the mixture of P and Q. With base-2 logarithms, the divergence lies in $[0,1]$. The composite consistency score is

$$S(P,Q) = 1 - \left(0.3\,\text{JS}_{\text{len}} + 0.4\,\text{JS}_{\text{freq}} + 0.3\,\text{JS}_{\text{sent}}\right), \tag{3}$$

where JS_{len}, JS_{freq} and JS_{sent} denote the divergences of the three distributions. We subsample both distributions to the same size, namely 120 content words and 8 utterances, in 20 draws. The *within-character* consistency $S(P_{c,\text{first}}, P_{c,\text{third}})$ compares the two modes of a character. The *between-character* consistency compares the character with the other characters of the scene within a mode. We regard character-specific traits as preserved only if the within-character consistency exceeds the between-character consistency.

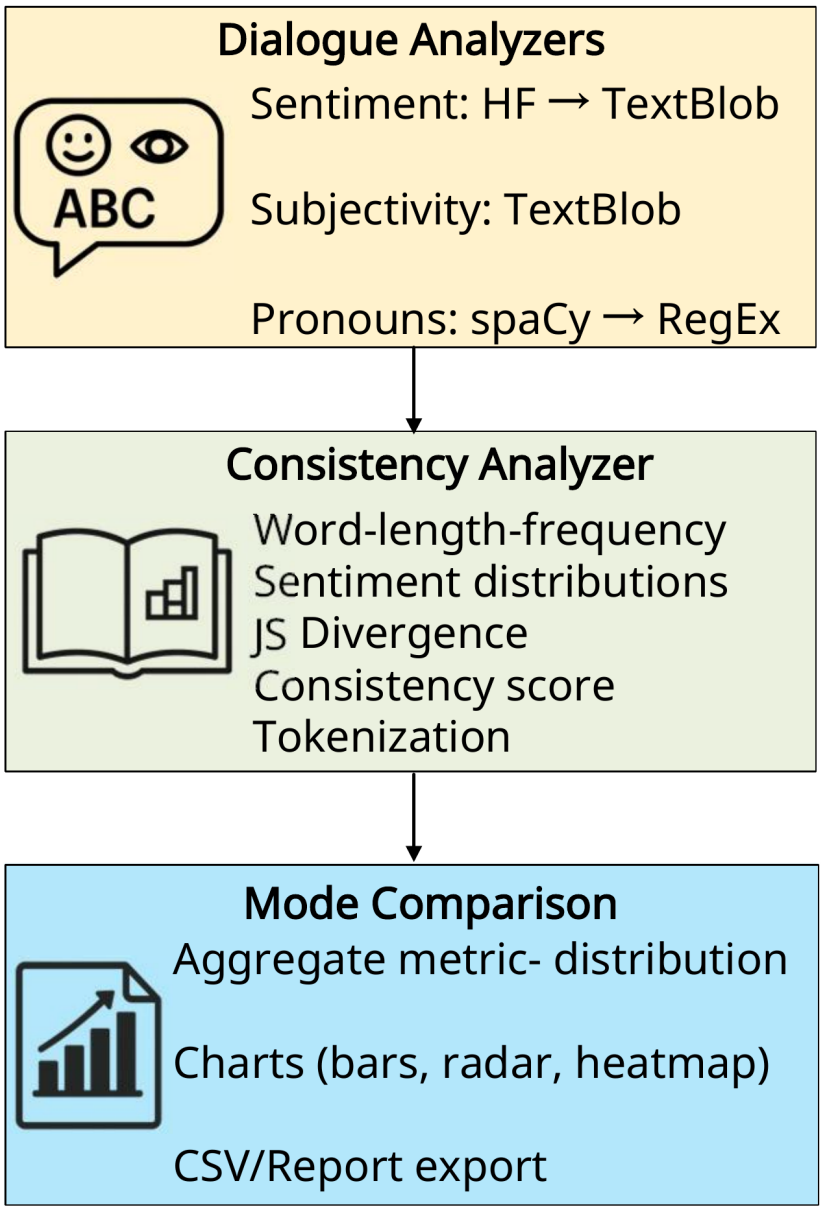


Figure 2. Software-level analysis pipeline. Dialogue analyzers capture sentiment, subjectivity, and pronoun statistics, while the consistency analyzer evaluates distributional features and outputs comparative metrics.

Speaker attribution. Speaker attribution is a more sensitive test of character identity. For every excerpt–model cell, we train a logistic-regression classifier that predicts the speaker of a turn. Its features are TF-IDF weighted content-word unigrams and bigrams without pronouns and names. A second classifier uses the frequencies of 96 non-pronoun function words instead. Characters with fewer than ten turns are omitted. We estimate within-mode accuracy with leave-one-seed-out cross-validation. For cross-mode accuracy, we train on one mode and test on the other. We compare the balanced accuracy with chance, which is $1/K$ for K characters, and with the within-mode accuracy across the 18 cells using Wilcoxon signed-rank tests.

2.4 Statistical procedures

The unit of analysis is the session. We first average the utterance-level values within each session to avoid pseudo-replication. Sessions that share the excerpt, the model and the seed form a block, and we compare the modes within blocks. For each measure and pair of modes, we report the mean paired difference with a 95% bootstrap confidence interval from 10,000 resamples of blocks (Efron and Tibshirani, 1993). The two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank test (Wilcoxon, 1945) tests the difference. Cohen's d_z and the matched-pairs rank-biserial correlation r_{rb} give the effect sizes. The Holm procedure adjusts the p-values within each family of comparisons (Holm, 1979). As a robustness check, we fit linear mixed models with mode and generator as fixed effects and a random intercept for the excerpt. To assess generalization, we count in how many of the 18 excerpt–model cells the mean difference has the same sign. All tests are two-sided with $\alpha = 0.05$.

2.5 LLM-judge evaluation

Two judge models evaluated the generated dialogues at temperature 0 as a scalable complement to the automatic measures. The first judge, `phi4:14b` (Abdin et al., 2024), comes from a developer different from those of the three generators. The second judge, `qwen3.5:9b` (Qwen Team, 2026), belongs to the same model family as one generator. Each judge rated every session on 1–5 scales for coherence, character consistency, scene fidelity, subjectivity and emotional intensity. It also classified the realized narrative form. The judges saw the excerpt metadata, the role cards and the dialogue, but not the generating model or the condition. In a speaker-identification task, each judge received four sampled turns per session from seeds 0–2. All names in these turns were masked, and gendered pronouns were neutralized. The judge identified the speaker among the characters of the scene and rated the subjectivity of the turn. Krippendorff's α quantifies the agreement between the judges (Hayes and Krippendorff, 2007). Subsection 3.10 describes a blinded expert evaluation of a subset.

2.6 Computing infrastructure

All experiments were run on a workstation with Ubuntu 24.04.5 LTS, an NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4070 Ti SUPER GPU (16 GB), 24 CPU threads and 30 GB of RAM. LLMs were served locally with Ollama 0.40.3 (Ollama, 2026) using 4-bit quantized weights. The analysis used Python 3.12 with spaCy 3.8 (`en_core_web_sm`), TextBlob 0.20, NLTK 3.10 (VADER), Transformers 5.17, wordfreq 3, SciPy 1.17, statsmodels 0.15, scikit-learn 1.9 and krippendorff 0.9.

3 EXPERIMENTS

3.1 Experimental Setup

Texts. We use six dialogue-rich excerpts by six authors that differ in genre, period and narrative structure (Table 1). They are a scene from *The Good Earth* (Buck, 1931); Darcy's first proposal from *Pride and Prejudice* (Austen, 1813); Pip's first meeting with Miss Havisham from *Great Expectations* (Dickens, 1861); the visit of the masked King in "A Scandal in Bohemia" (Doyle, 1892); Lady Bracknell's interview of Jack in *The Importance of Being Earnest* (Wilde, 1899); and the confrontation between Nikhil and Sandip in *The Home and the World* (Tagore, 1919). Together, they cover heterodiegetic narration, free indirect discourse, autodiegetic and homodiegetic first-person narrators, the dramatic mode and alternating narrators. Two of them have non-Western settings. The five additional texts are in the public domain and come from Project Gutenberg. For every excerpt, we compiled the cast with name aliases and attributed every quotation to its speaker manually. These annotations verify the cast and serve to evaluate the Director's extraction.

Table 1. Literary excerpts used in the experiments. Cast: characters represented by Actor Agents; Quotations: manually attributed direct-speech segments.

Excerpt	Source	Genre	Narrative structure	Words	Cast	Quotations
The Good Earth	Buck (1931), ch. 26	Realist family novel	Heterodiegetic, third person	901	4	11
Pride and Prejudice	Austen (1813), ch. 34	Novel of manners	Heterodiegetic, free indirect discourse	1063	2	14
Great Expectations	Dickens (1861), ch. 8	Bildungsroman	Autodiegetic, retrospective first person	531	2	24
A Scandal in Bohemia	Doyle (1891), part I	Detective story	Homodiegetic witness narrator	657	3	20
The Importance of Being Earnest	Wilde (1895), act I	Comic drama	No narrator (dramatic mode)	671	3	25
The Home and the World	Tagore (1916; tr. 1919), ch. 10	Political novel	Alternating first-person narrators	441	3	12

Models and parameters. Three open-weight instruction-tuned LLMs from different developers serve as generators: Llama 3.1 8B (Llama Team, AI @ Meta, 2024), Qwen2.5 14B (Qwen Team, 2024) and Gemma 3 12B (Gemma Team, 2025). Ollama serves all three locally with 4-bit quantization. Within a session, the same model plays the Director and all Actors. The configuration of the experiments is listed in Table 2.

Table 2. Experimental parameters and configurations.

Parameter	Value
Generator LLMs	`llama3.1:8b`, `qwen2.5:14b`, `gemma3:12b` (Ollama 0.40.3, Q4_K_M)
Judge LLMs	`phi4:14b`, `qwen3.5:9b-q4_K_M` (temperature 0)
Narrative modes	first person, third person, neutral (no instruction); improvement experiments: voice-preserving third person, speak-then-narrate
Maximum dialogue turns $T_{\max}$	20 generated turns per session
Generation temperature	0.7 (Director extraction and rewriting: 0)
Maximum tokens per response	1000 (extraction and single-prompt baseline: 3000–4000)
Context window	8192 tokens
Memory window k	5 turns (ablation: 1)
Speaker selection	addressee-aware softmax, $\alpha = 2.0$, $\beta = 1.5$, $\gamma = 1.0$, $\tau = 0.7$ (ablations: uniform, round robin)
Random seeds	0–4 (main experiment, improvement 1); 0–2 (ablations, extension, improvement 2)
JSON retry budget	3 attempts per call; mode enforcement: 1 regeneration + Director rewrite
Sentiment analysis	DistilBERT (SST-2), TextBlob, VADER
Subjectivity analysis	TextBlob
Pronoun and lexical analysis	spaCy `en_core_web_sm`, `wordfreq` Zipf frequencies

Design and number of runs. The main experiment simulated every combination of six excerpts, three generators, three narrative modes and five seeds once. It thus comprises 270 sessions of at most 20 generated turns. Sessions with the same excerpt, model and seed form a block and share the scene initialization, so the modes are compared in a paired design. The rule-based transposition baseline converts every first-person session into third-person reported speech. It substitutes pronouns and adds a reporting frame such as "O-lan told Wang Lung that ..." without changing the content. The ablations used Llama 3.1 8B on all six excerpts in both modes with seeds 0–2, which gives 36 sessions per condition. The extension and improvement experiments used all three generators. The voice-exemplar extension comprises 108 sessions in both modes with seeds 0–2. The voice-preserving instruction comprises 90 sessions with seeds 0–4, and the speak-then-narrate variant comprises 54 sessions with seeds 0–2. In total, we analyzed 702 sessions with 13704 generated turns. Of these sessions, 24 ended early because the selected characters remained silent four times in a row.

3.2 Scene initialization and pipeline reliability

The Director extracted the dialogue of the excerpts reliably (Table 3). Averaged over excerpts and models, it recovered 96.7% of the manually attributed quotations. After alias mapping, it attributed 93.2% of

them to the correct speaker. Only 2.5% of the extracted utterances could not be matched to the source text. Typical errors were merged or split quotations and misattributed short replies in multi-party scenes. Because the cast was verified and all modes within a block share the opening turns, such errors cannot create mode differences. With JSON-constrained decoding, none of the 15772 LLM calls produced unparseable output.

Mode enforcement kept the narrative modes apart. In the third-person mode, 95.8% of the turns complied at the first attempt. Regeneration corrected another 3.9% of the turns, and the Director rewrote 0.3%. Only 0.0% of the turns remained non-compliant. In the first-person mode, 99.8% of the turns complied at the first attempt.

Table 3. Director extraction quality and narrative-mode enforcement. Extraction is evaluated against manually attributed quotations (mean over six excerpts); enforcement figures are shares of generated turns in the main experiment. FP: first person; TP: third person.

Model	Quote recall	Attribution acc.	Fabricated	TP compliant (1st)	TP regenerated	TP rewritten	Residual (TP)	Residual (FP)
Llama 3.1 8B	0.96	0.95	0.02	0.932	0.060	0.008	0.000	0.000
Qwen2.5 14B	0.94	0.93	0.00	0.998	0.002	0.000	0.000	0.000
Gemma 3 12B	1.00	0.92	0.05	0.945	0.055	0.000	0.000	0.002

3.3 An example of the generated dialogues

Table 4 shows the first eight turns of two sessions that Qwen2.5 14B generated for the scene from *The Good Earth*. Both sessions share the role cards, the opening and the seed. The first-person session consists of direct speech such as “My wife, do not fret”. In the third-person session, a narrator reports the same kinds of speech acts, as in “Wang Lung reassured O-lan that . . . ”. The narrator occasionally adds gestures or inner states. Both sessions develop the situation of the source scene, which is O-lan’s wish to see her eldest son married before she dies. Neither session reproduces the novel. The Supplemental Information gives transcripts for all excerpts in Section S10.

3.4 Manipulation check and effects of narrative mode

We compared the session-level measures of the three instructed modes and of the rule-based transposition within paired blocks (Table 5). Figure 3 shows the standardized differences for all pairs of conditions.

Manipulation check. The mode instructions were realized as intended. First-person pronouns made up 0.846 of the first- and third-person pronouns in first-person sessions and 0.000 in third-person sessions. Without any instruction, the models also produced mainly first-person speech, with a first-person ratio of 0.800. First-person speech is therefore the default voice of role-playing LLMs. The third-person instruction is the manipulation that departs from this default.

Subjectivity and affect. TextBlob subjectivity did not differ between the modes. The mean first-minus-third difference was 0.003, and its 95% confidence interval included zero (Table 5). The difference was positive in only 9/18 excerpt–model cells. In contrast, emotional intensity was higher in first-person sessions, with a moderate effect size ($d_z = 0.45$). This difference was positive in 15/18 cells. TextBlob polarity differed in the same direction, whereas VADER polarity showed no reliable difference. The rule-based transposition left intensity and polarity unchanged, so the reporting form does not produce these differences. The DistilBERT score was also higher in first-person sessions. Part of this difference, however, comes from the reporting frame, which alone lowered the score by 0.061. The affective effects were strongest for Gemma 3 12B (Supplemental Information, S3).

Lexical register. The largest and most consistent differences concerned the vocabulary. Content words were longer in third-person narration than in first-person speech, with a large effect size ($|d_z| = 0.90$). They were also less frequent and more often rare (Table 5). The rule-based transposition changed both measures in the opposite direction. The effect is therefore not an artefact of substituting names for pronouns. It reflects the reporting verbs and the more formal diction of narration, for example *reassured*, *insisted* and *expressed*. Third-person turns were also longer, by 7.0 words on average. Most of this difference comes from the reporting frame, which alone added 5.8 words per turn. Lexical diversity was higher in third-person sessions by MATTR but not by MTLD. A higher lexical diversity of narration is therefore only partly supported.

Neutral control. The neutral sessions did not differ from the first-person sessions in emotional intensity or content-word length (see Fig. 3). The third-person sessions differed from both. Narration by

Table 4. Example of generated dialogue in the two narrative modes. First eight turns of the *The Good Earth* scene generated by Qwen2.5 14B (seed 0) with identical role cards and opening.

Mode	Turn	Speaker	Generated turn
First person	1	Wang Lung	My wife, do not fret. Our son will marry well and care for the fool as you have. The gods will see to it that all is well.
	2	O-lan	I know it is hard to let go, but you must look after them as I cannot. Ensure they are cared for and that the fool is well taken care of.
	3	Wang Lung	My dear, you must rest now. The eldest son will marry soon, and I will see to it that all your wishes are fulfilled. Do not worry, for I am here and will take care of everything.
	4	O-lan	I trust you, my husband, and I know you will do right by them. But promise me you will see to the fool's needs as I have.
	5	the eldest son	Mother, please rest assured. I will take care of everything as Father says. I will marry soon and look after the fool as you have.
	6	Wang Lung	My son, your words are a comfort. I will see to it that the wedding preparations are made and that your mother's last wishes are honored.
	7	the eldest son	Mother, please try to rest. Father and I will make sure everything is taken care of.
	8	O-lan	Thank you, my son. And Father, I know you will see to it. I only ask that you do not forget the fool's happiness above all.
Third person	1	Wang Lung	Wang Lung reassured O-lan that everything would be taken care of, that their son would be guided well and that she had no need to worry about him or the family. He insisted that he would see her wishes fulfilled and that her eldest son would have a good life.
	2	O-lan	O-lan asked Wang Lung if he had ensured that their son would be taught the ways of respect and duty towards his wife and her family, and if he had reminded him of the importance of providing for his wife and children.
	3	Wang Lung	Wang Lung assured O-lan that he would see to it that their son would be taught the ways of respect and duty, and that he would remind him of the importance of providing for his wife and her family, as she wished.
	4	O-lan	O-lan asked Wang Lung if he had spoken to the maid about the importance of her role in the family, and if he had reminded her of the duties she owed to her husband and his ancestors.
	5	the eldest son	The eldest son, feeling a mix of nervousness and devotion, told his mother that he understood the importance of respecting his wife and her family and would do his best to provide for them.
	6	the maid	The maid told O-lan that she had understood her duties and would serve the family with all her heart, ensuring that she respected her husband and his ancestors.
	7	O-lan	O-lan told Wang Lung and the others that she felt reassured by their words, but she asked Wang Lung to ensure that the arrangements for her son's marriage were completed swiftly, for her peace of mind.
	8	Wang Lung	Wang Lung told O-lan that he would personally oversee the arrangements for the eldest son's marriage, ensuring that everything was done swiftly and in accordance with tradition to bring her peace of mind.

an external narrator therefore dampens affect and raises the lexical register. First-person speech does not amplify affect relative to the models' default.

Table 5. Session-level means by narrative mode and paired first- vs. third-person comparisons (main experiment: 6 excerpts × 3 models × 5 seeds; $n = 90$ blocks). †Manipulation check. Rule-based: first-person sessions transposed to third person by pronoun substitution and a reporting frame. Δ: mean paired difference (first − third) with 95% bootstrap CI; d_z: Cohen's d_z; p_{Holm}: Wilcoxon signed-rank test, Holm-adjusted across the measures of the table; Cells > 0: excerpt–model cells (of 18) with a positive first − third difference.

Measure	First	Third	Neutral	Rule-based	Δ First−Third [95% CI]	d_z	p_{Holm}	Cells > 0
First-person ratio†	0.846	0.000	0.800	0.000	0.845 [0.820, 0.869]	7.17	<0.001	18/18
Self-reference by name†	0.3	2.0	0.3	1.9	−1.7 [−1.8, −1.5]	−2.23	<0.001	0/18
Subjectivity	0.486	0.483	0.499	0.486	0.003 [−0.019, 0.024]	0.03	1.000	9/18
Emotional intensity	0.205	0.171	0.218	0.205	0.034 [0.018, 0.050]	0.45	<0.001	15/18
Polarity (TextBlob)	0.121	0.092	0.124	0.121	0.028 [0.010, 0.046]	0.33	0.025	16/18
Polarity (VADER)	0.208	0.189	0.254	0.199	0.019 [−0.032, 0.069]	0.08	1.000	10/18
Polarity (DistilBERT)	0.223	0.062	0.284	0.162	0.161 [0.088, 0.235]	0.45	<0.001	12/18
Utterance length (words)	34.2	41.2	32.5	40.1	−7.0 [−9.1, −5.0]	−0.71	<0.001	5/18
Content-word length	6.669	7.054	6.719	6.450	−0.386 [−0.474, −0.298]	−0.90	<0.001	2/18
Content-word Zipf frequency	4.616	4.501	4.602	4.690	0.114 [0.084, 0.145]	0.78	<0.001	15/18
Rare-word rate	0.039	0.048	0.041	0.037	−0.009 [−0.014, −0.004]	−0.38	0.002	4/18
MATTR	0.843	0.870	0.860	0.805	−0.027 [−0.043, −0.012]	−0.36	0.009	7/18
MTLD	70.9	72.5	76.5	62.4	−1.6 [−5.7, 2.3]	−0.08	1.000	9/18

3.5 Generalization across texts and models

The main differences generalized across texts and models (see Fig. 4). Content-word length was higher in third-person narration in 16/18 excerpt–model cells. Zipf frequency, emotional intensity and polarity were higher in first-person turns in 15/18, 15/18 and 16/18 cells, respectively. The other measures were less consistent. The DistilBERT difference was positive in 12/18 cells, and MATTR was higher in third-person narration in 11/18 cells. The sign of the subjectivity difference was split evenly, with 9/18 positive cells. Linear mixed models with a random intercept for the excerpt led to the same conclusions as the paired tests (Supplemental Information, S2). Several effects depended on the generator. Gemma 3 12B produced much longer third-person than first-person turns, whereas the other two models differed by fewer than five words. Effects found for one model on one text should therefore not be generalized without replication.

3.6 Character-level Analysis

The four characters of *The Good Earth* followed the pattern of the whole corpus (see Fig. 5; Table 6). In both modes, they used content words of similar length. Third-person narration shifted all of them towards longer and less frequent words. The differences between characters were small compared with the differences between modes.

Table 6. Character-level lexical statistics for *The Good Earth* (all models and seeds pooled). *S* within: composite consistency of the same character between its first- and third-person turns; *S* between: mean consistency with the other characters of the scene in the same mode (averaged over models; characters with fewer than 120 content words in a mode are omitted).

Character	Mode	Turns	Content words	Word length (SD)	Zipf	Subjectivity	*S* within	*S* between
O-lan	First	87	848	5.94 (2.03)	4.98	0.434	0.943	0.945
	Third	82	1020	6.43 (2.12)	4.81	0.466		
Wang Lung	First	75	689	5.56 (1.90)	5.01	0.462	0.937	0.941
	Third	72	941	6.40 (2.12)	4.77	0.451		
the eldest son	First	62	466	5.81 (2.14)	5.02	0.494	0.932	0.942
	Third	56	694	6.47 (2.29)	4.85	0.556		
the maid	First	29	227	5.70 (2.19)	4.98	0.446		
	Third	24	234	6.50 (2.36)	4.81	0.440		

Switching the narrative mode changed the subjectivity of individual characters in both directions (see Fig. 6). In a Bland–Altman analysis (Bland and Altman, 1986), the mean difference between a character's first- and third-person subjectivity was close to zero, at 0.003. The limits of agreement were wide, and the

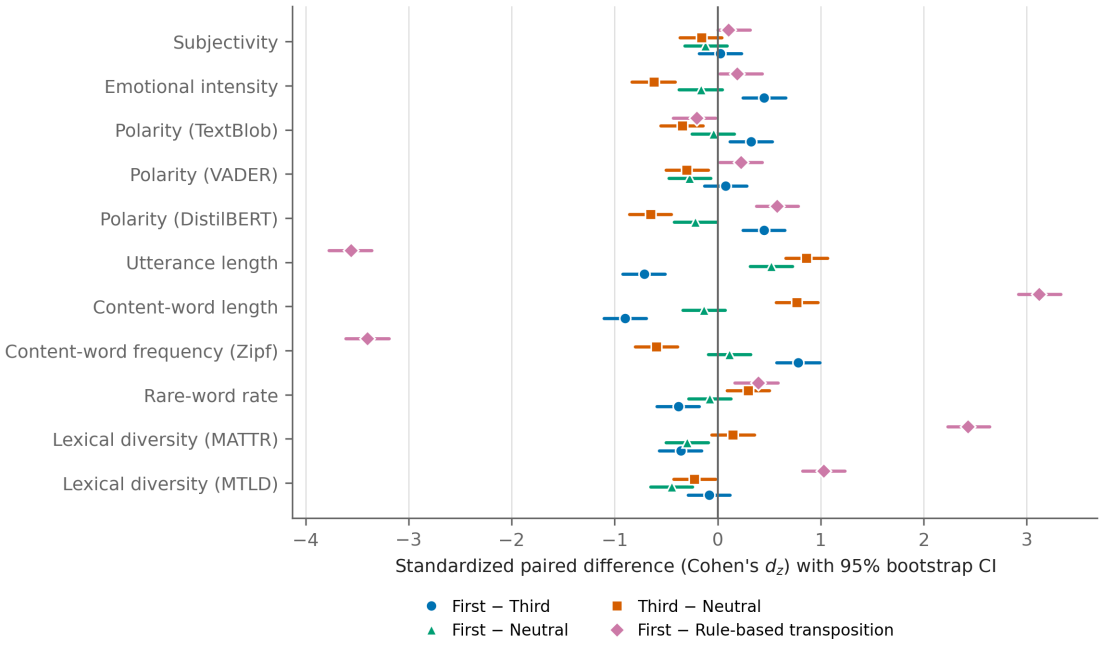


Figure 3. Standardized paired differences between narrative modes. Points show Cohen's d_z of the session-level differences for each measure and pair of conditions; bars show 95% bootstrap confidence intervals ($n = 90$ excerpt–model–seed blocks). Rule-based transposition: first-person sessions converted to third person by pronoun substitution and a reporting frame, without any change of content.

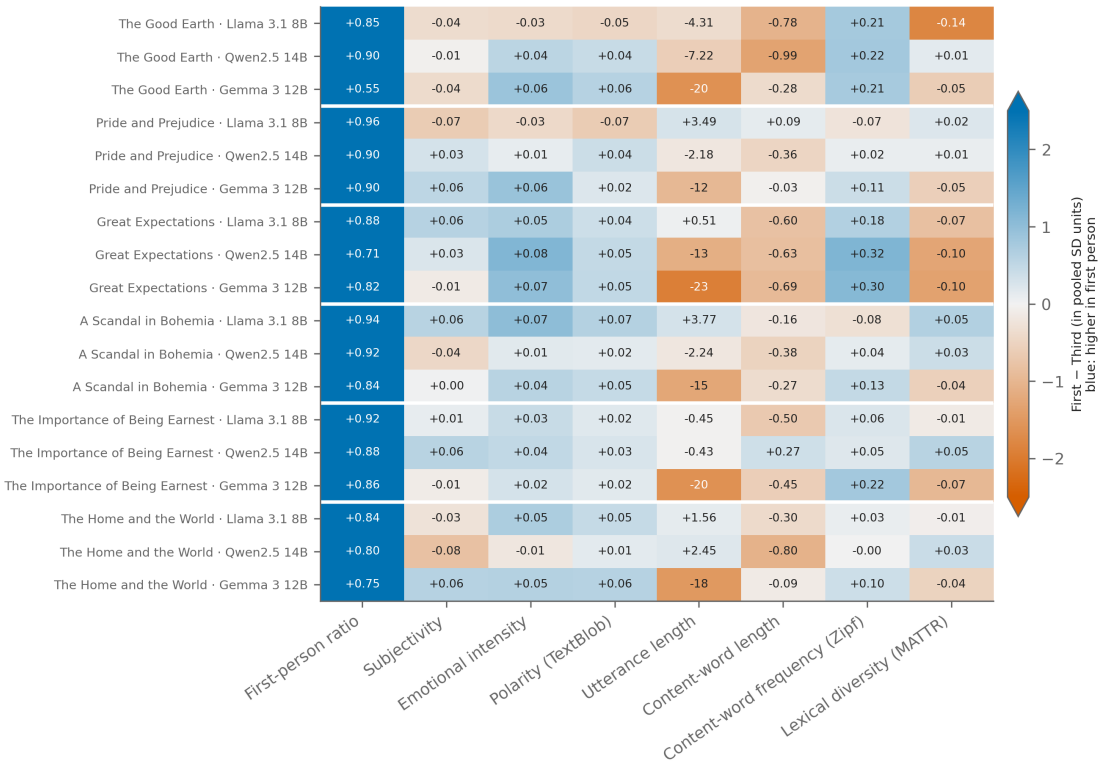


Figure 4. First- minus third-person differences for every excerpt and generator. Cells show the mean difference of the session-level measure over five seeds; colors show the difference in units of the pooled standard deviation (blue: higher in first person; orange: higher in third person; saturated at ± 2.5).

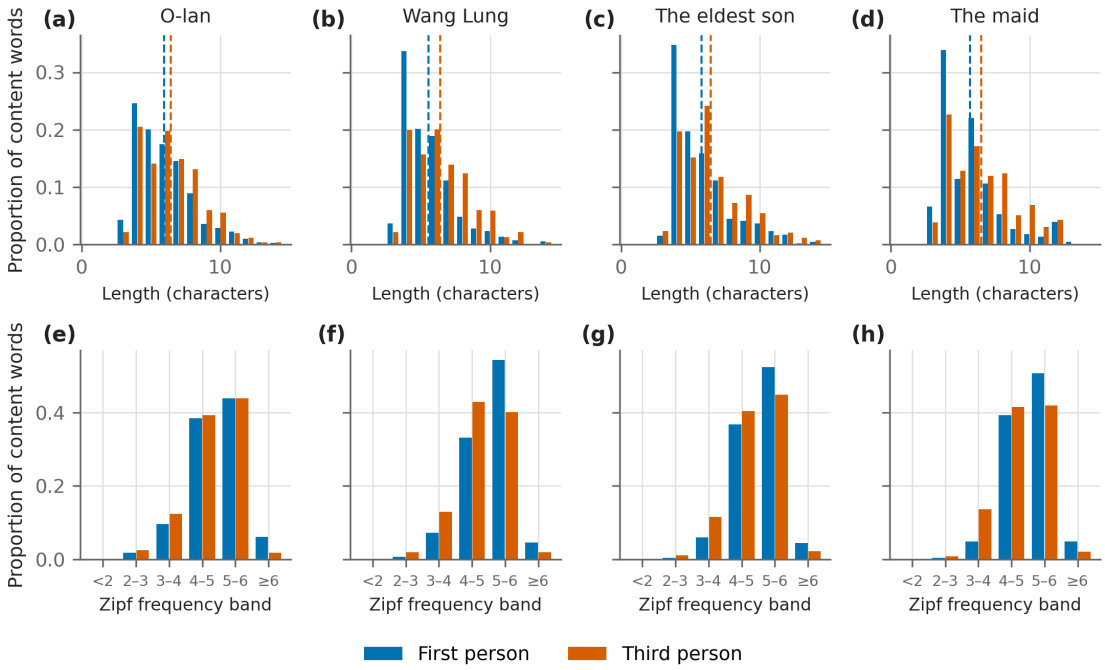


Figure 5. Content-word length (a–d) and word-frequency (e–h) distributions of the four characters of *The Good Earth* in first-person (blue) and third-person (orange) sessions (all models and seeds pooled). Dashed lines: mean word length. Frequency bands are Zipf frequencies from `wordfreq`.

sign of the difference depended on the character, the text and the model. Single runs can therefore suggest a subjectivity difference in either direction.

Are character-specific traits preserved across modes? Small Jensen–Shannon divergences between a character's first- and third-person turns indicate preserved traits only if the characters differ from one another. We therefore compared each character's cross-mode consistency with its consistency with the other characters of the scene (see Fig. 7a). The two scores were practically identical, with a mean S of 0.936 within characters and 0.933 between characters (Wilcoxon $p = 0.347$, $n = 47$). The distributional measure thus reflects the shared style of the generator rather than character identity.

Speaker attribution is more sensitive. Within a mode, the content-word classifier identified the speaker with a balanced accuracy of 0.84, against a chance level of 0.38. Across modes, accuracy dropped to 0.63 (see Fig. 7b). This accuracy was above chance in 18 of 18 cells (Wilcoxon $p < 0.001$). It was, however, lower than the within-mode accuracy (Wilcoxon $p < 0.001$). A classifier based on function words showed the same pattern at a lower level. Character identity is therefore partially preserved. The agents keep their topics and concerns, while the narrative frame changes how they express them.

Turn-level subjectivity fluctuated around a stable level in all three modes (see Fig. 8). It showed neither a systematic trend nor a separation between the modes.

3.7 Ablation study: narrative control, memory and speaker selection

We compared ablated versions of the framework with the full framework on the same excerpts, modes and seeds (Table 7; see Fig. 9). All ablations used Llama 3.1 8B. A single-prompt baseline, in which one LLM call writes the whole continuation, served as an additional comparison.

Narrative control. Without a perspective instruction, the models rendered the turns as first-person speech. The instruction is therefore necessary to obtain third-person narration. Without the Director's compliance check and rewriting, 10.3% of the third-person turns violated the mode. The first-minus-third difference in the first-person ratio then fell from 0.898 to 0.833 ($p = 0.002$). The single-prompt baseline hardly separated the modes, with a difference of only 0.350, because many of its *third-person* turns were still direct speech. Turn-level control of narrative voice therefore requires the multi-agent design with explicit enforcement.

Actor memory. A memory of one turn instead of five did not change subjectivity or lexical diversity.

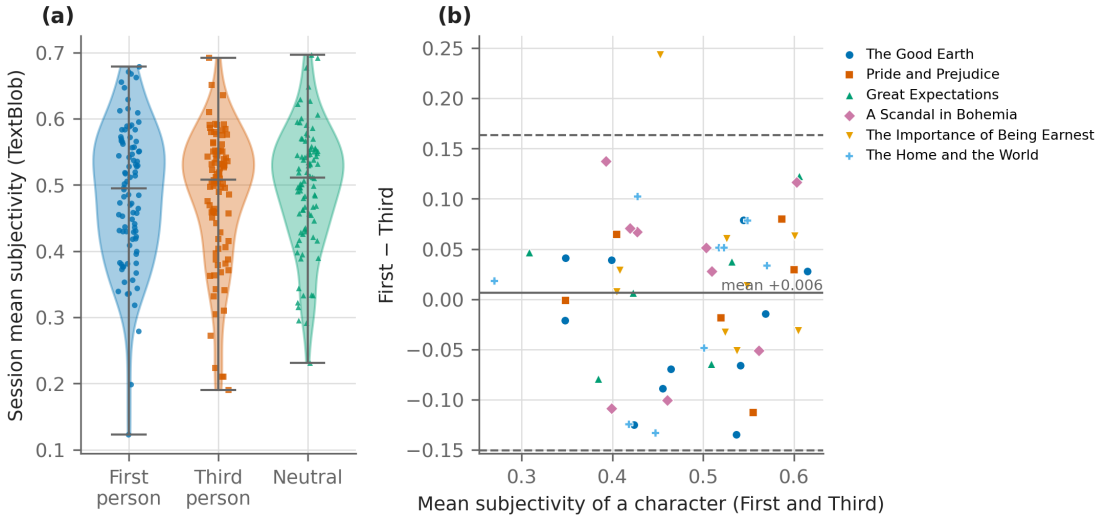


Figure 6. Subjectivity by narrative mode. (a) Session-level mean subjectivity in the three modes ($n = 90$ sessions each). (b) Bland–Altman plot of character-level subjectivity in first- versus third-person sessions; solid line: mean difference; dashed lines: 95% limits of agreement.

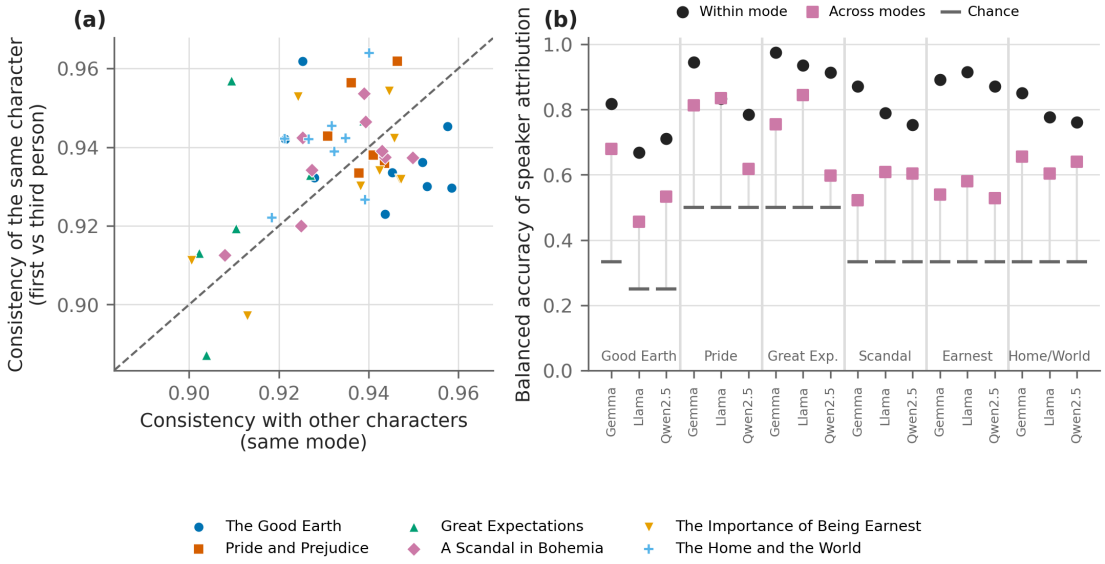


Figure 7. Character identity across narrative modes. (a) Composite distributional consistency S of each character between its first- and third-person turns (y) against its mean consistency with the other characters of the scene in the same mode (x); points above the diagonal would indicate preserved character-specific traits. (b) Balanced accuracy of speaker attribution from content words within a mode (leave-one-seed-out) and across modes (trained on one mode, tested on the other) for every excerpt–model cell; horizontal bars mark chance.

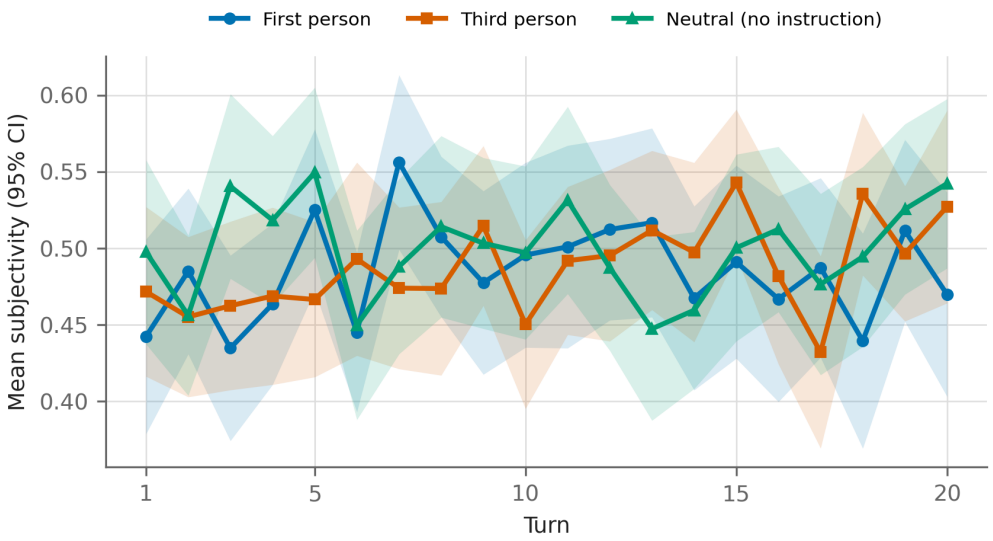


Figure 8. Turn-level subjectivity by narrative mode (mean over all excerpts, models and seeds with 95% confidence bands).

It lowered, however, the share of turns that complied with the mode at the first attempt from 0.957 to 0.899 ($p = 0.003$). The recent turns thus also serve as in-context examples of the required form.

Speaker selection. With the addressee-aware policy, the addressed character answered in 90.8% of the turns. Under uniform random selection and a round-robin order, the shares were 34.0% and 66.4%, respectively (both $p < 0.001$). Uniform selection also let a character speak twice in a row in 46.5% of the turns. None of the policies changed the narrative-mode effects (Table 7).

Judged quality. Both LLM judges rated the sessions with uniform speaker selection as the least coherent. Phi-4 gave them 4.25 and the full framework 4.39. Qwen3.5 gave them 3.14 and the full framework 3.61. In contrast, both judges rated the single-prompt baseline as the most coherent, with 4.69 and 3.92. The multi-agent design is therefore not needed for fluency but for turn-level control of voice, speaker and addressee.

Table 7. Ablation results (Llama 3.1 8B; 6 excerpts × 2 modes × 3 seeds per condition), compared with the full framework on the same excerpts, modes and seeds. Responsiveness: share of turns by the character addressed in the previous turn; turn balance: normalized entropy of the speaker distribution; self-succession: share of consecutive turns by the same speaker; repetition: 1 − share of distinct word trigrams; compliant (1st) and residual viol.: share of turns that followed the mode at the first attempt and after enforcement. Gap: mean first − third difference of subjectivity and of the first-person ratio within a block. *Paired Wilcoxon test against the full framework, $p < 0.05/6$.

Condition	Responsiveness	Turn balance	Self-succession	Repetition	Compliant (1st)	Residual viol.	Gap subj.	Gap FP ratio
Full framework	0.908	0.955	0.007	0.150	0.957	0.000	−0.015	0.898
−Memory ($k = 1$)	0.938	0.935	0.006	0.140	0.899*	0.010	0.009	0.913
−Speaker selection (uniform)	0.340*	0.974	0.465*	0.131	0.944	0.001	0.015	0.912
−Speaker selection (round robin)	0.664*	0.999*	0.000	0.148	0.968	0.001	0.032	0.895
−Mode enforcement	0.904	0.956	0.009	0.139*	0.949	0.051*	−0.029	0.833
Single-prompt baseline	0.808	0.968	0.004	0.116	–	–	0.049	0.350

3.8 LLM-judge evaluation

The two judges agreed only weakly with each other (Table 8; see Fig. 10). Krippendorff's α was 0.41 for subjectivity, 0.23 for coherence and 0.01 for emotional intensity. It was negative for character consistency and scene fidelity, which Phi-4 rated near the maximum. We therefore interpret the two judges separately.

Qwen3.5 classified the narrative form of 100.0% of the first-person and 100.0% of the third-person sessions as instructed. Phi-4 labelled many third-person sessions as "mixed" and classified only 46.7% of them correctly. Phi-4 found no difference between the modes in perceived subjectivity or emotional intensity ($p = 0.618$ and $p = 0.209$, respectively). Qwen3.5 rated third-person sessions lower on every

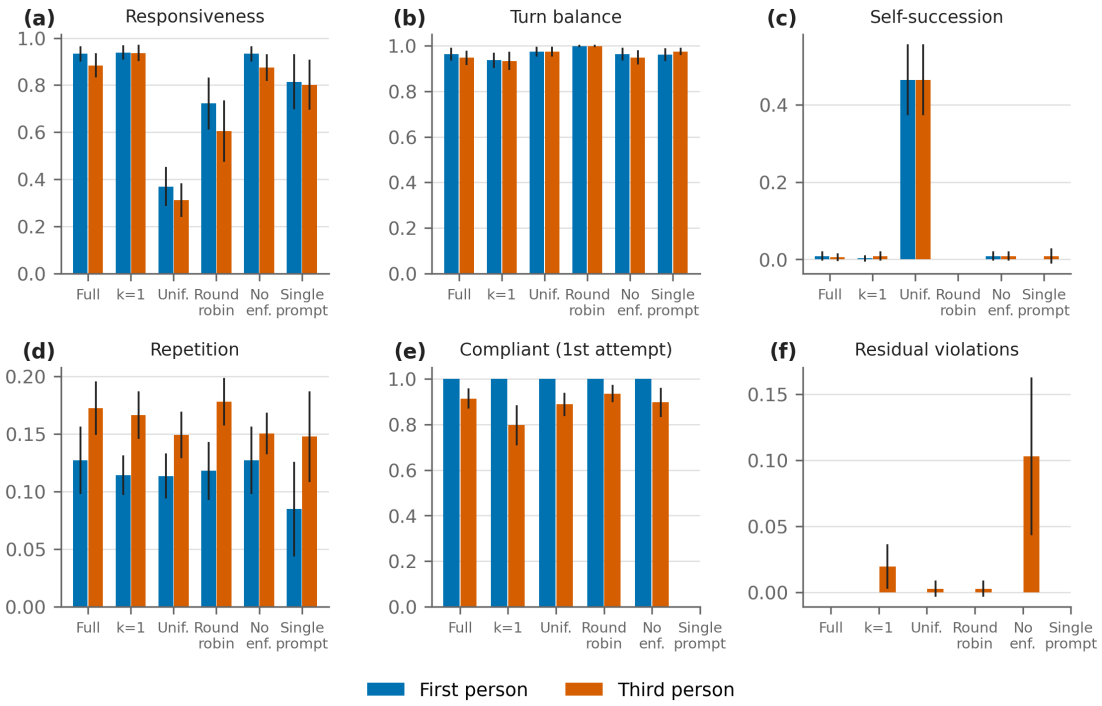


Figure 9. Ablation of memory, speaker selection and mode enforcement, and the single-prompt baseline (Llama 3.1 8B, 6 excerpts, 3 seeds; blue: first-person sessions, orange: third-person sessions; error bars: 95% confidence intervals). (a) Addressee responsiveness; (b) turn-taking balance; (c) self-succession; (d) repetition; (e) mode compliance at the first attempt; (f) residual mode violations after enforcement. Full: full framework; $k = 1$: memory of one turn; Unif.: uniform speaker selection; Round robin: fixed speaker order; No enf.: without Director enforcement; Single prompt: single-prompt baseline.

criterion, including character consistency and scene fidelity (all $p < 0.001$). Because these two criteria should not depend on the narrative form, the pattern suggests a general preference for direct-speech dialogue rather than a specific perception of lower subjectivity. The subjectivity ratings of both judges correlated only weakly with TextBlob subjectivity, with Spearman coefficients of 0.13 and 0.12. Perceived subjectivity is therefore measure-dependent.

In the masked speaker-identification task, both judges identified the speaker far above chance in both modes (binomial tests, $p < 0.001$). Phi-4 had an accuracy of 0.89 for first-person and 0.88 for third-person turns. Qwen3.5 had 0.91 and 0.89, against a chance level of 0.38. Because the judges saw the role cards, this result shows that the turns remain tied to their characters' situations and concerns in both modes.

Table 8. LLM-judge evaluation of the main-experiment sessions (1–5 scales; $n = 90$ sessions per mode and judge). Form correct: share of sessions whose dominant narrative form was classified as the instructed one. Speaker ID: accuracy of identifying the speaker of a turn with all names masked (chance level in parentheses).

Judge	Mode	Coherence	Char. consistency	Scene fidelity	Subjectivity	Emot. intensity	Form correct	Speaker ID (chance)
Phi-4 14B	First	4.73	5.00	4.89	3.62	3.86	0.69	0.89 (0.38)
Phi-4 14B	Neutral	4.71	5.00	4.89	3.60	3.76	–	0.92 (0.38)
Phi-4 14B	Third	4.62	4.99	4.83	3.59	3.78	0.47	0.88 (0.37)
Qwen3.5 9B	First	4.53	3.64	2.89	4.16	3.47	1.00	0.91 (0.38)
Qwen3.5 9B	Neutral	4.54	3.64	2.84	4.20	3.52	–	0.93 (0.38)
Qwen3.5 9B	Third	3.74	2.43	1.96	2.93	2.48	1.00	0.89 (0.37)

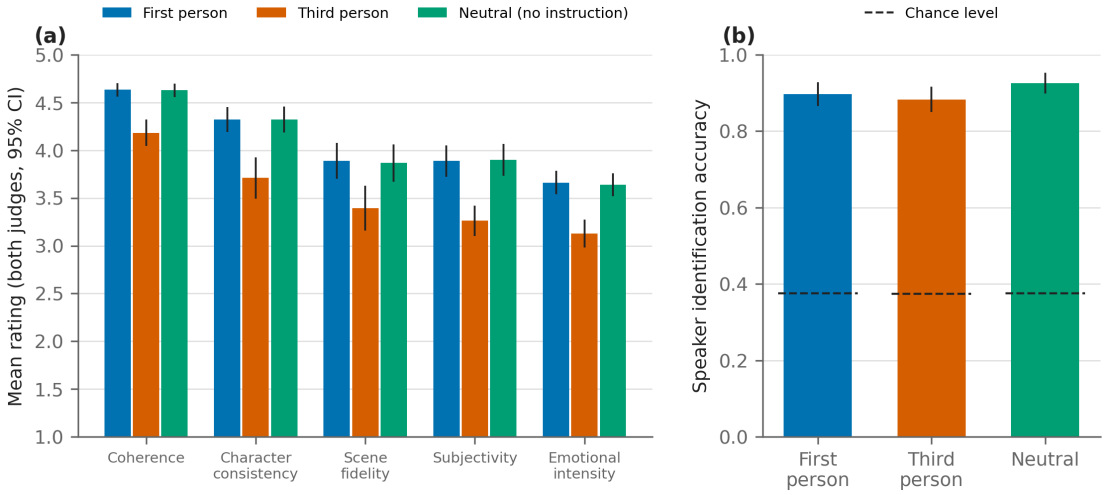


Figure 10. LLM-judge evaluation. (a) Mean ratings of the main-experiment sessions by narrative mode (both judges pooled; error bars: 95% confidence intervals). (b) Accuracy of masked speaker identification by narrative mode (both judges pooled); dashed lines mark chance.

3.9 Improving the preservation of character identity

The standard third-person mode loses part of the characters' identity and shifts their vocabulary towards the narrator's register. We therefore tested three ways of keeping the characters' voice in third-person narration. All three change only the narrative-mode component. We compared each of them with the standard framework on the same excerpts, generators and seeds (Table 9; Supplemental Information, S11).

Voice exemplars. The first variant adds up to three of each character's lines from the excerpt to the role card (Appendix A.7). These exemplars did not make the characters more distinguishable. Cross-mode attribution was 0.60 with exemplars and 0.60 without them. Compliance at the first attempt fell from 0.978 to 0.957. The exemplars are direct speech, so they pulled third-person turns back towards direct speech.

Voice-preserving instruction. The second variant asks the narrator to keep the character's own words, idioms and tone, as in free indirect style. It raised cross-mode attribution from 0.63 to 0.67 ($p = 0.074$). It

also reduced the register shift in content-word length from 0.46 to 0.38 characters. Compliance, however, dropped sharply. Only 67.7% of the turns followed the third-person form at the first attempt, and 4.0% still contained direct speech after enforcement. Both judges rated these sessions as less coherent.

Speak-then-narrate. The third variant separates what a character says from how the narrator reports it. The Actor receives the first-person instruction and speaks in the character's own voice. The Director then turns this speech into third-person narration in free indirect style. It changes only pronouns, tense and at most a short reporting phrase (Appendix A.7). Because the Actor prompt is identical to that of the first-person condition, this variant isolates the contribution of the narration itself. Mode control remained reliable, with 0.6% residual violations. Cross-mode attribution rose from 0.60 to 0.73 and was higher in 17 of 18 cells ($p < 0.001$). The register shift largely disappeared. Narrated turns no longer differed reliably from first-person speech in content-word length, word frequency or emotional intensity (Supplemental Information, S11).

The LLM judges assessed this variant less favorably. They identified the speakers of narrated turns less accurately than those of standard third-person turns. Phi-4 had an accuracy of 0.78 against 0.88, and Qwen3.5 had 0.81 against 0.89. Their coherence ratings fell from 4.61 to 4.30 for Phi-4 and from 3.67 to 2.22 for Qwen3.5. Turns that keep the character's wording without explanatory framing possibly read as less natural.

Summary. What matters for character identity is who formulates the third-person turn. When the narrator paraphrases the turn, the vocabulary shifts towards the narrator's register. When the narration only transposes the character's words, the lexical identity of the characters is largely preserved, at the price of lower judged coherence. The more formal register of third-person narration in our simulations is thus produced by narratorial paraphrase rather than by the grammatical person. Content words were 7.04 characters long in standard third-person turns and 6.73 characters long in narrated turns ($p_{\text{Holm}} < 0.001$). We keep the standard mode as the main condition because it corresponds to conventional narratorial report. Speak-then-narrate is available as an option for studies that need to hold the characters' wording constant.

Table 9. Attempts to preserve character identity in third-person narration. Each cell gives the value of the variant and, in parentheses, the value of the standard framework on the same excerpts, models and seeds. Compliance and residual violations refer to third-person turns (voice exemplars: both modes). Cross-mode attribution: balanced accuracy of a content-word classifier trained on one mode and tested on the other (first person vs. the variant's third-person mode). Speaker ID: accuracy of the LLM judges on masked third-person turns (seeds 0–2). |FP−TP|: mean absolute first-minus-third difference per excerpt, model and seed (content-word length in characters; emotional intensity).

Variant	Sessions	Compliant (1st)	Residual viol.	Cross-mode attribution	Speaker ID Phi-4	Speaker ID Qwen3.5	|FP−TP| word length	|FP−TP| intensity
Voice exemplars (both modes)	108	0.957 (0.978)	0.002 (0.000)	0.60 (0.60)	0.86 (0.88)	0.86 (0.89)	–	–
Voice-preserving instruction	90	0.677 (0.958)	0.040 (0.000)	0.67 (0.63)	0.87 (0.88)	0.89 (0.89)	0.38 (0.46)	0.054 (0.063)
Speak-then-narrate	54	0.894 (0.958)	0.006 (0.000)	0.73 (0.60)	0.78 (0.88)	0.81 (0.89)	0.26 (0.47)	0.044 (0.055)

3.10 Expert evaluation

To check the automatic measures and the LLM judges against human readers, three raters evaluated a blinded subset of the generated dialogues. Two raters hold master's degrees in English literature, and one holds a master's degree in English drama. The subset comprised 12 sessions from four excerpts: *Pride and Prejudice*, *Great Expectations*, "A Scandal in Bohemia" and *The Home and the World*. For each excerpt, one generator contributed a first-person, a standard third-person and a speak-then-narrate session, each with seed 0 and the first eight turns. The raters also identified the speakers of 36 masked turns drawn from those that the LLM judges had rated. They did not know the generator or the condition. They rated every session on the 1–5 scales of the judges for coherence, character consistency, subjectivity and emotional intensity, and they classified its narrative form. The instructions were in Chinese, and the dialogues were in English. We asked the raters to work independently and without AI tools. One of the authors, who was not blind to the conditions, entered their responses into the rating sheets. The item-level ratings are released with the data (Supplemental Information, S12).

The experts agreed moderately to substantially. Krippendorff's α ranged from 0.55 for emotional intensity to 0.79 for coherence and thus exceeded the agreement of the LLM judges, whose α was at most 0.41. This comparison rests, however, on far fewer sessions. The experts identified the speakers of masked turns far above chance in all three conditions (binomial tests of the majority vote, $p = 0.004$ or smaller).

Their accuracy was 1.00 for first-person, 0.86 for standard third-person and 0.97 for speak-then-narrate turns, against a chance level of 0.42. On the same turns, Phi-4 and Qwen3.5 had accuracies of 0.75 and 0.75, respectively.

Like the judges, the experts rated the speak-then-narrate sessions as the least coherent. Their mean coherence rating was 2.33 for these sessions, 3.25 for first-person sessions and 2.83 for standard third-person sessions. Perceived subjectivity differed little between the conditions, with means of 4.08, 3.83 and 4.17. The session ratings of the experts correlated moderately with those of the judges, with Spearman coefficients between 0.45 and 0.69. They also correlated with the automatic measures of subjectivity and emotional intensity, with coefficients of 0.68 and 0.43, respectively. Each condition mean rests on four excerpts, and an author transcribed the responses. We therefore report these results descriptively and regard them as a plausibility check rather than as a test of the hypotheses.

4 DISCUSSION

4.1 Interpretation of Findings

Our experiments support some of the hypotheses that motivated this study and not others. First, the framework controlled narrative voice reliably across six excerpts and three generators. Second, the clearest consequence of switching from first-person speech to third-person narration was a more formal lexical register. This shift was consistent across texts and models and ran opposite to the shift that pronoun substitution produces. Third, third-person narration was affectively more neutral. The comparison with the no-instruction control shows that narration dampens affect, not that first-person speech amplifies it, and the effects were small to moderate. Fourth, lexicon-based subjectivity did not change, the two LLM judges disagreed on perceived subjectivity, and the experts perceived little difference between the modes. In our simulations, these results support the hypothesis that third-person narration promotes a more neutral and descriptive register. They support stronger emotional polarity in first-person speech only in this relative sense. They do not support the hypothesis that first-person narration increases subjectivity, at least as measured here.

At the character level, the Jensen–Shannon measure did not distinguish characters, so it cannot show that traits are preserved. Even a small divergence would characterize only the simulations produced here and not the approach in general. Speaker attribution, the judges and the experts indicate that character identity is partially preserved across modes. The improvement experiments locate the loss in the narrator's paraphrase. When the narration only transposes the character's own speech, cross-mode attribution rises and the register shift largely disappears.

4.2 Prompt design and the interpretation of perspective effects

In any prompt-based manipulation, differences between modes may be direct consequences of the prompts. Our analysis separates three kinds of effects. Effects that the instruction states explicitly, such as the pronoun profile, are manipulation checks. Effects of rendering a turn as reported speech are estimated by the rule-based transposition. This baseline accounts for most of the difference in utterance length and for part of the DistilBERT difference. It does not account for the differences in content-word length, word frequency, intensity and polarity. Only effects beyond the transposition indicate how the generators realize the instruction to narrate. Even these effects describe LLMs that were instructed to write in a given mode, and they may depend on the wording of the instructions. The source texts provide a reference point. In the five prose excerpts, narration had a higher TextBlob subjectivity than quoted speech, 0.379 against 0.267. Its content words were also longer, with 6.14 against 5.49 characters. Lexicon-based subjectivity thus mainly reflects evaluative and descriptive adjectives, which narrators use at least as much as characters. It does not capture the experiential subjectivity that narratologists associate with first-person narration. The absence of a subjectivity effect is therefore partly a limitation of the measure.

4.3 Strengths and Limitations

The framework integrates character modeling, narrative-mode control and quantitative analysis into a replicable pipeline. Its prompts are fixed, its random choices are seeded, and all model responses are cached. We release the code, the dialogues and the analysis scripts. The paired design keeps the role cards, the opening and the seed constant across modes. The conclusions rest on six texts, three models and five seeds and on paired tests with correction for multiple comparisons.

Several limitations remain. First, the results describe three 4-bit quantized open-weight models of 8–14B parameters. Larger or proprietary models may realize the modes differently. Second, the excerpts are short single scenes in English, one of them in translation. The findings may not extend to long-form narrative, other languages or other scenes. Third, the automatic measures were developed for other domains. Their validity for literary dialogue is limited, as the comparison with the source texts shows. Fourth, the LLM judges are not a substitute for human evaluation. One of them belongs to the same model family as a generator, and they agreed only weakly, with α at most 0.41. One judge also preferred direct-speech dialogue in general. The expert evaluation was small, with 3 raters and 12 sessions. An author who was not blind to the conditions transcribed its responses, and it did not include lay readers. Fifth, the cast lists were verified manually, and the Director's extraction still misattributes some quotations. Finally, the modes manipulate grammatical person and narratorial mediation but not focalization.

Narratological implications. Within these limits, the simulations suggest three hypotheses that can be tested with human-authored texts and readers. First, narratorial mediation is expressed through a more formal vocabulary and a moderate dampening of affect rather than through a change of lexicon-based subjectivity. Second, a change of narrative voice preserves what characters talk about more than how they say it, unless the narrator stays close to the characters' own words, as in free indirect style. Third, first-person direct speech is the default voice of role-playing LLMs, which should be considered when such models are used to simulate narrative.

5 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

We have proposed an LLM-driven multi-agent simulation framework for studying narrative voice shifts under controlled conditions. In this framework, a Director Agent enforces the narrative mode, and Actor Agents with a sliding-window memory generate the dialogue. We have evaluated it on six excerpts by six authors with three open-weight models and five seeds, and it has controlled narrative voice reliably. In our simulations, third-person narration was associated with a more formal vocabulary and a lower emotional intensity than first-person speech, whereas lexicon-based subjectivity did not change. Character identity was only partly preserved across modes. A speak-then-narrate variant has preserved character identity much better and has removed most of the register shift, which indicates that the shift arises from narratorial paraphrase. These results support some of the hypotheses that motivated this study and not others. They also show why single-run results from one text and one model should not be generalized.

In our future work, we will evaluate the framework with more literary experts, lay readers, larger models, longer texts and other languages. We will also develop measures of narratorial subjectivity and focalization that suit literary text better than general-purpose sentiment lexicons.

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APPENDIX: PROMPT TEMPLATES

All prompts are fixed templates; text in angle brackets is filled in by the framework. JSON output is additionally enforced with the JSON mode of the Ollama API. The complete source code is available in the project repository.

A.1 Dialogue extraction (Director, temperature 0).

```
Extract the direct-speech dialogue from the following literary excerpt, in order of appearance.
Rules:
1. Include only spoken utterances (no narration, inner thoughts or action descriptions).
2. If an utterance is interrupted by narration, merge the parts into one utterance.
3. "speaker": use the character's name if it is known from the excerpt; otherwise the first
     descriptive reference (e.g. "the old lady"). Use exactly the same label for the same person
     throughout. Never invent labels such as "Speaker A".
4. "speak_to": always a non-empty array of addressee labels (use the same labels as for speakers);
      infer the addressee from context if it is not explicit.
Return only JSON of the form {"dialogues": [{"speaker": "...", "speak_to": ["..."], "text":
     "..."}]}.
Excerpt:
<excerpt>
```

A.2 Role cards (Director, temperature 0).

```
You are the Director of a dialogue simulation. Based on the literary excerpt and its extracted
     dialogue, build a role card for every character who speaks.
Return only JSON of the form:
{"characters": [{"name": "...", "gender": "female|male|unknown", "personality": "...", "
     emotional_baseline": 0.0, "speech_style": "...", "description": "...", "relationships": {"
     Other name": "relation"}}],
 "context": "two or three sentences summarising the situation of the scene"}
"emotional_baseline" is a number in [-1, 1]. Use exactly these speaker labels as names: <cast
     names>.
Excerpt: <excerpt>
Extracted dialogue: <dialogue>
```

A.3 Narrative-mode instructions (inserted into the Actor prompt).

```
FIRST PERSON:  NARRATIVE MODE: FIRST PERSON. Write <name>'s turn as direct speech in <name>'s own
     voice. <name> refers to himself or herself with first-person pronouns (I, me, my). Do not add
     a narrator, quotation marks, or descriptions of <name> in the third person.
THIRD PERSON:  NARRATIVE MODE: THIRD PERSON. Do not write direct speech. Write <name>'s turn as
     narration by an external narrator, as in a novel: report what <name> says (and, if relevant,
     does or feels), naming <name> and using a reporting verb (told, asked, insisted, ...). Never
     use I, me, my, we, our, you or your, and no quotation marks. Example. Direct speech: John said
      to Mary, "I'm tired and don't want to go to the party." Third-person narration: John told
     Mary that he was tired and had no intention of going to the party.
NEUTRAL:       (no instruction)
```

A.4 Actor Agent (temperature 0.7, seeded).

```
You are role-playing the literary character <name> in a multi-character scene.
Role card:
- Name: <name>   - Personality: <personality>   - Speech style: <speech style>
- Background: <description>   - Relationships: <relationships>
- Current emotion (-1 negative .. 1 positive): <emotional baseline>
Scene: <context>
Other characters present: <other names>
Recent dialogue (oldest first):
<last k turns, one per line: "speaker (to addressees): text">
Instructions: Stay in character. Decide what <name> says next, consistent with the role card and
     the recent dialogue. Advance the scene; do not repeat earlier turns. Keep the turn to one to
     three sentences.
<narrative-mode instruction>
Return only JSON: {"intend": "speak" or "silent", "content": "<mode-specific description>", "
     speak_to": ["addressee name(s)"]}
```

When a turn violates the mode, the line "IMPORTANT: a previous answer did not follow the narrative mode (¡reason¿). Follow the NARRATIVE MODE exactly." is appended to the mode instruction for the second attempt. If the second attempt also fails, the Director rewrites the turn with the prompt: "You are the Director of a dialogue simulation and you enforce the narrative mode. Rewrite the following turn of ¡name¿ (addressed to ¡addressees¿) so that it follows the mode below. Keep its meaning, tone and length; change only the narrative form. ¡mode instruction¿ Turn: ¡text¿".

A.5 Single-prompt baseline (temperature 0.7, seeded).

```
Write the continuation of the following literary scene as a dialogue of exactly <n> turns among
     these characters: <names>.
Role cards: <one line per character>
Scene: <context>
Opening of the scene: <last five opening turns>
<mode text: first person = "Every turn must be direct speech in the speaker's own voice using
     first-person pronouns (I, me, my); no narrator and no quotation marks." / third person = "
     Every turn must be third-person narration by an external narrator reporting what the speaker
     says (by name or he/she, never 'I'), with no direct speech or quotation marks.">
Each turn is one to three sentences. Return only JSON of the form {"turns": [{"speaker": "...", "
     speak_to": ["..."], "text": "..."}]} with <n> items.
```

A.6 LLM judges (temperature 0).

```
SESSION TASK: You are an expert in literary studies evaluating a computer-generated continuation
     of a scene from "<title>" by <author>. Characters: <role cards>. Scene context: <context>.
     Continuation (<n> turns): <numbered turns>.
Rate the continuation on each criterion from 1 (very poor / very low) to 5 (excellent / very high):
      coherence (the turns follow sensibly from one another and form a meaningful exchange);
     character_consistency (each character's turns fit the character description and stay
     consistent); scene_fidelity (the continuation is plausible for this scene of the work:
     situation, relationships, period); subjectivity (how strongly the turns foreground personal
     opinions, evaluations and feelings; 1 = detached and factual, 5 = highly personal);
     emotional_intensity (1 = flat, 5 = intense). Also classify the dominant narrative form as "
     first_person_direct_speech", "third_person_narration" or "mixed". Return only JSON.

SPEAKER TASK: ... One turn of a generated dialogue is shown below. All character names were
     replaced by [NAME] and gendered pronouns by neutral ones, so you must decide from the content
     and style alone. Turn: <masked turn>
1) Which character most probably produced this turn? Answer with one name from this list: <names>.
2) Rate the subjectivity of the turn from 1 (detached, factual) to 5 (highly personal, evaluative,
      emotional). Return only JSON: {"speaker": "...", "subjectivity": 1-5}
```

A.7 Extension and improvement experiments.

```
VOICE EXEMPLARS (added to the Actor's role card): Voice examples (lines that <name> speaks in the
     source text; imitate the voice and diction, not the content):
- "<line 1>"  - "<line 2>"  - "<line 3>"
VOICE-PRESERVING THIRD PERSON (mode instruction of improvement 1): NARRATIVE MODE: THIRD PERSON,
     VOICE-PRESERVING. Do not write direct speech. Write <name>'s turn as narration by an external
     narrator, referring to <name> by name or he/she, never as "I", and use no quotation marks or
     the pronouns I, me, my, we, our, you or your. Keep <name>'s own words, idioms, tone and
     characteristic expressions as far as possible (free indirect style): report the turn in <name
     >'s voice instead of paraphrasing it in the narrator's formal language. Example. Direct speech
     : John said to Mary, "I'm dead tired and I won't go to that silly party." Voice-preserving
     narration: John was dead tired, he told Mary, and he would not go to that silly party.
SPEAK-THEN-NARRATE (improvement 2; the Actor receives the FIRST PERSON instruction, then the
     Director, temperature 0): You are the narrator of a novel. Turn the following direct speech of
      <name> (addressed to <addressees>) into third-person narration in free indirect style.
Rules: keep <name>'s own words, idioms, imagery and tone; change only what the narrative form
     requires: first-person pronouns (I, me, my, we, us, our) become <name>, he, she or they;
     second-person pronouns (you, your) become the addressee's name, he, she or they; verbs shift
     to the past tense. Do not use quotation marks or the pronouns I, me, my, we, us, our, you or
     your. Do not add commentary, interpretations or feelings that are not in the speech; at most
     add a short reporting phrase such as "he told Mary".
```

```
Example. Direct speech of John to Mary: I’m dead tired and I won’t go to that silly party.
     Narration: John was dead tired, he told Mary, and he would not go to that silly party.
Speech: <the Actor’s turn>
Return only JSON: {"content": "..."}
```